

CASTE SYSTEM IN INDIA — Part 3

Paper 2 • Chapter 3.2 • Sarthi IAS Foundation • Handout 3 • Nataraj Sir

CHAPTER 3.2 — CASTE SYSTEM (Part 3)

A. 7 Theories of Origin of Caste

Traditional • Brahmanical • Racial • Occupational • Ketkar • Senart • Hutton (Mana)

B. Dominant Caste (Srinivas)

3 Original + 3 New Criteria • Examples • Relevance • 5 Criticisms

C. Caste Mobility

5 Types Upward • 6 Enabling Factors • 5 Types Downward

A. THEORIES OF ORIGIN OF CASTE

There are many theories put forward to explain the origin of the caste system in India, but **none gained universal acceptance**. The caste system is a **complex and multifaceted social phenomenon**, shaped by religious, cultural, economic & political influences. Its origins cannot be traced to a single factor.

A.1 Traditional Theory

Core: Hindu society = a **supernatural-centred society** where people are lured by abstract truth & search for it through **mysticism, not science**. Caste has been **established by divine ordinance** or at least with divine approval.

Two Versions:

VERSION	EXPLANATION
(a) Mythical	Four varnas = four castes. These four castes emerged from different parts of Brahma's body . A man is born in a particular caste because of his actions (karma) performed in his previous incarnation . Birth in a caste is not an accident .
(b) Metaphysical	Each caste has a separate function determined by the nature (swabhav) and the qualities (guna) of its members. E.g.: If a person is born to rule → he becomes part of Kshatriyas.

Criticism — Rejected by scholars for 2 reasons:

1. It considers caste as a **natural phenomenon**
2. It considers **four varnas as four castes** (oversimplification)

M.N. Srinivas

"The idea of caste as the four-fold division of society represents a **gross oversimplification of facts**. The **real unit** of the caste system is **jati** (not varna)."

A.2 Brahmanical Theory (Abbe Dubois)

Core: Caste system **originated and developed in India because of Brahmins**. It is an **ingenious device made by Brahmins for Brahmins**.

- **Brahmins imposed restrictions** on eating, drinking, marriage & social relations with non-Brahmins **to preserve their purity**
- They gave themselves a **high status and special privileges** and prerogatives in the Brahmana and other books
- They **declared all others as inferior** to them
- **Ghurye also agrees** — caste-society was the result of attempts by Brahmanic civilisation to **exclude the aborigines and the Sudras** from religious and social communion with themselves

Criticism — Hutton argues against it:

1. If this theory is accepted, it would mean that **caste must have originated at a date when Brahmins had political power**
2. Hutton thinks **caste did not originate so late** — it predates Brahmin political power

A.3 Racial Theory (Risley)

Core: The **clash of cultures and the contact of races** crystallised castes in India.

- Migrant **Aryans had their own ideas of ceremonial purity & considered the original inhabitants as inferior**
- **Aryans were essentially patrilineal** while the **local population they conquered were matrilineal**
- They married the daughters of the **aboriginals but refused to give their daughters to them** (hypergamy)
- The **children of "irregular union"** had to be assigned the **lowest position** in society → called **chandalas**

- Thus, the origin of the group of "**half-breeds**" as well as the feeling of **racial superiority** ultimately became **responsible for the origin of the caste system**

Risley's 6 Processes of Caste Formation:

#	PROCESS	MECHANISM
1	Change in traditional occupation	Adopting a new occupation → a caste or sub-division develops into a distinct caste
2	Migration	A section migrates to another region → difficult to maintain contacts → completely cut off from parental caste → develops as a new caste
3	Change in customs	Formation of new castes by discarding old customs & adopting new practices — familiar since earliest times
4	Preservation of old traditions	Certain castes cherish traditions & preserve old traces . To separate from those who adopted new customs, they take a new name → new caste
5	Enrolling into Hinduism	An entire tribe or section becomes " Hinduised " & takes a new caste name . E.g.: Maria Gonds of MP; Rajbanshis of Bengal
6	Role of religious enthusiasts	A religious enthusiast preaches his own doctrines → followers form a separate sect → ultimately develops as a new caste

Criticism:

- If Risley's racial theory is accepted, it would mean that the **caste system should not be confined to India** but should be found in **all those societies** which have faced conquests by other racial groups
- Therefore, the question arises: **Is caste a unique Indian phenomenon?**

A.4 Occupational Theory (Nesfield)

Core: The origin of caste has **nothing to do with racial affinity or religion** — it is **mainly due to functions or occupations**.

- The **technical skill of the occupation was passed on hereditary from generation to generation**
- Because of practising the same occupation over a long period, "**occupational guilds**" came into existence which **later on came to be known as castes**
- The **hierarchy in the caste system** was the result of the feeling of the **superiority and inferiority of occupations**

Criticism — D.N. Majumdar:

- Criticised Nesfield's idea of hierarchy based on **superiority or inferiority of occupations**
- He maintains that the **status of castes depends not on the superiority of the inferiority of occupation but upon the degree of purity of blood** and the extent of **isolation maintained by the groups**

A.5 Ketkar's Theory

Core: Ketkar **traces the origin of castes from the early tribes**, where each tribe group was **endogamous** and was **hostile to other tribes** for resources. He believes that **castes are "developed tribes" or "converted groups"**.

Criticism:

- Accepting the origin of castes from tribes **would mean accepting that the caste system was evolved not by the Aryans** but by the native Dravidian aborigines
- History can definitely be cited as proof that the **caste system did not exist in the pre-Vedic period** but evolved only in the **post-Vedic period** — tribals in the pre-Vedic period can under **no circumstances be held responsible** for the creation of castes

A.6 Senart's Theory (1930)

Core: Traces the **origin of the caste system to the Aryan sources**. His book: *Caste in India* (1930).

- **Indians, Greeks and Romans are all Aryans** and their civilisations are the oldest ones
- Senart finds **certain similarities in the three systems**:
 - **India:** Family, Gotra, Caste
 - **Rome:** Gens, Curia, Tribe
 - **Greece:** Family, Phratry, Phyle
- Just as **caste panchayats exist in India** and its head (sarpanch) is an all-powerful man, in **Rome and Greece too there are similar councils with similar powers**
- On the basis of these comparisons, Senart maintains that caste developed as a **natural course of development of these ancient Aryan institutions**

Criticism — Dahlmann's main arguments:

- The **origin of caste cannot be explained only in terms of certain elements**
- Such a complex institution must be the result of **multiple forces**

A.7 Hutton's Theory of Mana (1961)

Core: Hutton emphasised the "**primitive**" conception of **mana** in the formation of castes.

- **Mana** = a **mysterious impersonal power** attached to individuals, objects and places
- **Taboos** were imposed on commensality, inter-marriage and interaction, etc. **to save the members of one's tribe from the**

mana of the other tribes

- The **restriction on sharing food** with others and having contacts with them is based on the **belief that these (food and contacts) may be infected with the dangerous mana**
- **Evidence:** In his **study of Nagas in 1923-24**, Hutton found **villagers objected to accepting presents or money** from strangers **for fear of the influence of the mana** attached to those objects

Criticism — D.N. Majumdar (1952):

- Though tribes in **other societies also believe in mana** but we do **not find a caste system there**
- Hutton himself considers caste as an **outcome of interaction of geographical, social, political, religious and economic factors** — not mana alone

Conclusion — Multifactor Theory:

Scholars like  **S.C. Roy** and  **R.K. Mukherjee** supported the **Multifactor Theory**, arguing that several factors working together over time led to the emergence of the Indian caste system. In essence, the caste system is a **complex and multifaceted social phenomenon**, shaped by religious, cultural, economic, and political influences. Its origins cannot be traced to a single factor or event, but are the outcome of a **long and layered historical process**, highlighting the need for a nuanced understanding of its evolution and its implications for contemporary Indian society.

Master Comparison — All 7 Theories at a Glance

THEORY	SCHOLAR(S)	CASTE ORIGINATED FROM...	KEY CONCEPT	CRITICISED BY
Traditional	Vedic texts	Divine ordinance / Brahma's body / Karma	Supernatural-centred society; Swabhav & Guna	M.N. Srinivas (jati ≠ varna)
Brahmanical	Abbe Dubois, Ghurye	Brahmins' device for purity & privilege	Ingenious device; exclusion of Sudras	 Hutton
Racial	Risley	Clash of Aryan & aboriginal races	Half-breeds; racial superiority; 6 processes	Caste should exist globally then
Occupational	Nesfield	Hereditary occupational guilds	Occupational hierarchy	 D.N. Majumdar
Ketkar	Ketkar	Early endogamous, hostile tribes	Developed tribes = converted groups	Pre-Vedic tribes ≠ caste creators
Senart	Senart (1930)	Aryan institutional development	India-Rome-Greece parallel	 Dahlmann
Hutton (Mana)	Hutton (1961)	Fear of mana → taboos → caste	Mysterious impersonal power; Naga study	 D.N. Majumdar (1952)
Multifactor Theory:  S.C. Roy & R.K. Mukherjee — caste = complex product of multiple forces (religious, cultural, economic, political)				

ANTHROPOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

- **Methodological lesson:** No single-factor theory explains caste → anthropology must adopt **holistic, multi-causal approaches** (functionalist + historical + structural)
- **Emic vs Etic:** Traditional theory = emic (insider's religious view); Racial/Occupational = etic (outsider's scientific analysis) — both needed for complete understanding
- **Colonial construction:** Risley's census-based ranking of castes **hardened fluid jati boundaries** into rigid categories — Nicholas Dirks (*Castes of Mind*) argues British anthropology **co-produced modern caste**
- **Relevance today:** Debates on caste origin inform **reservation policy** (are castes racial/occupational/divine?) and **anti-caste movements** (Ambedkar rejected divine origin, emphasised power dimension like Brahmanical theory)
- **Comparative anthropology:** Senart's India-Rome-Greece comparison pioneered **cross-cultural structural analysis** — a method central to Levi-Strauss's structuralism

B. DOMINANT CASTE (M.N. Srinivas)

DOMINANT CASTE — M.N. Srinivas

Concept & Definition

3 Original Criteria

3 New Criteria

Village → Regional

Regional Examples

Sanskritization Link

Culture Preservation

Dispute Settlement

4 Contemporary Dimensions

5 Criticisms

B.1 Concept & Definition

M.N. Srinivas — Paper: "Dominant Caste in Rampura"
"Dominant Caste" = a term used to refer to those castes which had a **large population** and were **granted land rights** by the partial land reforms that came into effect after Independence.

- The concept gave us a **new insight about the process of social change** in India
- The land reforms **took away rights from the erstwhile claimants** — the upper castes who were "**absentee landlords**" in the sense that they played no part in the agricultural economy other than claiming their rent
- So the middle castes with land, numbers & local status became the **new power centres** in villages

B.2 Srinivas's Original 3 Criteria

#	CRITERION	HOW IT CREATES DOMINANCE
1	Sizable amount of cultivable land	Economic resources & control over agricultural production → translates into political and social power
2	Considerable numerical strength	Large voting bloc → ability to mobilise resources and influence public opinion
3	Reasonably high place in local caste hierarchy	Social prestige & cultural capital → can translate into economic & political power as well as control over social norms and values

B.3 How Are the Criteria Changing?

Mere ownership of land, numerical strength and high place in ritual hierarchy are **no longer the only determining factors**. Now **western education, jobs in administration, and political clout** and contacts are the new and additional features. The introduction of **adult franchise, democratic decentralisation, reservation** and spread of education among the depressed has further changed the criteria.

NEW CRITERION	HOW IT CONTRIBUTES TO DOMINANCE
Political Clout	Allows a caste to control the decision-making process and access to resources → greater economic and social power
Western Education	Provides skills & knowledge valued in modern society → greater economic opportunities and social mobility
Jobs in Administration	Access to positions of power and influence → control important aspects of society: law enforcement, public policy, and governance

B.4 Village Level → Regional Level Dominance

Due to expansion in transport and communication, **village level dominance is no longer enough** to make a caste dominant. Instead, **regional level dominance** seems to be a better criterion.

5 Pillars of Regional Dominance: Substantial Numerical Strength + Political Clout + Ownership of Land + Education + Jobs in Administration

B.5 Examples of Dominant Castes (by Region)

REGION	DOMINANT CASTE(S)
Mysore villages	Lingayat and Okkaliga
Andhra Pradesh	Reddy and Kamma
Tamil Nadu	Gounder, Padayachi and Mudaliar
Kerala	Nair
Maharashtra	Maratha
Gujarat	Patidar
Northern India	Rajput, Jat, Giyar and Ahir

B.6 Dominant Caste & Sanskritization

Key insight: Sanskritization for lower castes is **NOT always Brahmins** — it is the **Dominant Caste** that lower castes try to emulate and climb up the social ladder.

Case: Thakur Landlords (Eastern UP)

In certain areas of eastern Uttar Pradesh, the dominant **Thakur landlords** make the Brahmins cook food except their *kulguru* (family priest). Lower castes emulate Thakurs, not Brahmins.

Case: Jat Landlords (Punjab)

In many Punjab villages, **Jat landlords view Brahmins as their servants**, reflecting the emulation of Jats in this context. Lower castes aspire to Jat lifestyle.

B.7 Role in Culture Preservation

- The Dominant Caste usually **keeps its distance from others in the village and the whole region of dominance**
- It considers itself as the **protector and watchdog of culture**
- It **sets certain norms of behaviour**, the violation of which is dealt severely

B.8 Dominant Caste & Dispute Settlement

- Dominant Castes **settle the disputes** through the traditional **village and caste councils**
- They not only settle the disputes **among the members of different castes** but also **among the members of their own caste**

B.9 Contemporary Significance (4 Dimensions)

#	DIMENSION	DETAILS & CASE STUDIES
1	Political Mobilisation & Electoral Power	With adult franchise and Panchayati Raj, numerical strength of dominant castes has become central to politics . Case: <i>Yadavs in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh</i> transformed their demographic weight into political dominance through leaders like Lalu Prasad Yadav and Mulayam Singh Yadav . ✎ Yogendra Yadav shows how dominant OBC castes act as " vote banks " shaping regional parties (e.g., RJD, SP).
2	Cultural Hegemony & Emulation	Dominant castes remain cultural models for lower castes. Srinivas noted that Sanskritization often targets the lifestyle of dominant regional groups, not just Brahmins . Case: <i>Jats in Punjab</i> or <i>Thakurs in UP</i> being emulated by lower castes in rituals, food practices, and marriage customs.
3	Erosion & Contestation	Dominance is increasingly challenged by SC/ST assertion, reservations, and social movements . Case: <i>Dalit movements in Maharashtra</i> (Ambedkarite mobilisation) and the rise of BSP in UP disrupted traditional dominance of Marathas and Thakurs. Still, dominant castes adapt by forming alliances or repositioning within party politics.
4	Changing Basis — Beyond Land	Andre Beteille (2003) observed that dominance is no longer tied only to land . Access to education, bureaucracy, and political networks is now crucial. Case: <i>Lingayats in Karnataka</i> and <i>Reddys in Andhra Pradesh</i> dominate through educational institutions and political representation, not just agriculture.

B.10 Criticism / Limitations (5 Points)

1. Dominant Individuals vs Dominant Caste

✎ **S.C. Dube and Peter Gardner**

Argued that dominance is often held by **individuals or factions** within a caste rather than by the caste as a whole.

- Dube emphasised that calling an entire caste dominant **only makes sense if power is shared widely** and exercised for the benefit of most members
- In reality, **inequalities of wealth and prestige exist within** so-called dominant castes
- Dominant individuals often **exploit weaker members of their own caste** along with members of other castes

Srinivas's Response to Critics: He accepted that there are dominant individuals and factions but argued that **their influence derives from belonging to a dominant caste**. In his words: *"Dominant individuals and dominant factions owe their dominance to the fact that they are part of the dominant caste."* Thus, individual or factional dominance **cannot be separated from caste identity**.

2. Changing Basis of Dominance

-  **D.N. Majumdar**'s study of **Mohana village** (Uttar Pradesh, 1958) showed that Brahmins and Thakurs were dominant due to **zamindari**
- But **after abolition of zamindari**, Thakur dominance weakened though they **retained some power through moneylending**

- This shows that **dominance based purely on land is not permanent**. With land reforms, **political power and new economic bases** became more important

3. Numerical Strength not Decisive

-  **D.N. Majumdar** argued that **numerical size alone does not ensure dominance**
- In many villages the **Scheduled Castes** (like Lodha or Pasi in UP) may be **numerically largest**, but authority still rested with a **few upper-caste landlord families**

4. Political Dominance via Numbers

- On the other hand, scholars like  **Andre Beteille** and  **Yogendra Singh** emphasised that under **adult suffrage**, **numerical strength became crucial for political dominance**, especially for SCs and STs with **reserved seats**

Conclusion: The concept of **dominant caste**, introduced by **M.N. Srinivas**, has been significant in anthropology as it helps in understanding the **social hierarchies and power dynamics** in Indian society. It has been applied to study **caste-based social stratification** and the role of caste in shaping **political and economic relationships** in villages. In contemporary Indian villages, the relevance of the dominant caste concept can still be seen, as it continues to influence the **social and political life** of people. Dominant castes continue to **control local politics and hold economic power**, while lower castes face **discrimination and marginalisation**.

ANTHROPOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

- **Village studies tradition:** Srinivas's concept emerged from his **Rampura fieldwork** — a milestone in the Indian village studies tradition that shaped Indian social anthropology
- **Power beyond ritual:** The concept showed that **power in Indian villages is not solely ritual/religious** (as Dumont's *Homo Hierarchicus* suggested) but also **economic and political** — a corrective to purely ideological models
- **Subaltern studies link:** Critics (Dube, Gardner) anticipated subaltern critique — dominance is **contested, not monolithic**; internal differentiation within castes matters
- **Electoral anthropology:** Concept directly applicable to studying **caste-politics nexus** — vote banks, caste associations, Mandal politics (Yogendra Yadav's work on OBC mobilisation)
- **Policy relevance:** Understanding which castes are "dominant" helps in **correctly targeting affirmative action** — e.g., creamy layer debate, Jat/Patidar/Maratha reservation demands
- **Globalisation impact:** New bases of dominance (education, bureaucracy, diaspora networks) show how **caste adapts to modernity** rather than disappearing — relevant for Andre Beteille's work on **"caste in a changing world"**

C. CASTE MOBILITY

CASTE MOBILITY

Definition & Nature

5 Types of Upward Mobility

6 Enabling Factors

5 Types of Downward Mobility

Warfare • Serving Rulers • Census • Sanskritization/Westernization • Politics

Jajmani Decline • Modern Jobs • Untouchability Decline • Education • Reservation • Social Movements

Zamindari Abolition • Green Revolution • Service Caste Decline • Failed SC Mobility • Jagirdar Withdrawal

C.1 Definition & Nature

Caste mobility is **NOT** a new phenomenon — it has been prevalent in society for many centuries.

It refers to the process where the **members of lower caste try to raise their social status in the caste hierarchy** and also the **caste as a group attempts mobility** by gaining political power or through the process of **politicisation of castes**.

Silverberg

Talked about social mobility in India through **renunciation** — the lower castes tried to perform the acts of **sannyasins** in order to increase their social value and to escape the deprivation of their own place in social hierarchy.

M.N. Srinivas

Through his studies of **Sanskritization and Westernization**, explained the caste mobility process.

C.2 Five Types of Upward Caste Mobility

Type 1: Mobility through Warfare

Pauline Kolenda

Referred to caste mobility through warfare in the Mughal period. The most effective way to rise in the caste hierarchy is by the **acquisition of territory** either through **conquest or by peaceful occupancy of sparsely populated or empty land**.

Case Study: Shivaji & the Marathas

 **M.N. Srinivas** gave the example of **Shivaji** (Maratha King — **Sudra varna**) in the Mughal period who **overthrew Mughal rule** and established the Maratha empire. He went through the **religious rites of transition into Kshatriyahood**. Along with Shivaji's rise in his caste, the **Marathas as a whole became Kshatriyas**.

Type 2: Mobility through Serving Rulers

- Jatis, whose members served either **Hindu or non-Hindu castes**, acquired **higher Varna rank**

Case Study: Patidars of Gujarat

Patidars of Gujarat — an efficient group of **Shudra Varna** — supported Maratha descendants of Shivaji (Gaekwads) who ruled central Gujarat. Gradually, claiming to be Kshatriyas, they **established their own regimes**.

Type 3: Mobility through Census Commissioners

- While recording jati identities in census enumerations from **1891 to 1931**, many middle and low castes made efforts to get themselves **registered as members of twice-born castes**
- Herbert Risley**, the census commissioner, tried to rank all castes. **Hundreds of jatis tried to get ranked high** by claiming their Varna titles

Case Studies: Census Mobility

- Kurmi cultivators** of Bengal → wanted to be called **Kurmi Kshatriyas**
- Teli** (oil pressers) → wanted to be called **Vaishyas**

Type 4: Mobility through Sanskritization & Westernization

M.N. Srinivas in 1952, through the process of Sanskritization and Westernization, explained caste mobility.

PROCESS	DEFINITION & FEATURES
Sanskritization	A process by which a low caste was able to rise in a generation or two to a higher position in the hierarchy by adopting Vegetarianism and Teetotalism . They take over rituals, customs, rites and beliefs of the Brahmins and give up their own practices which might be considered to be impure .
Westernization	The process of emulating the western cultures by adopting ideology, values, institutions and technology as a result of cultural contact with western society for a long period. The important feature of westernization is emphasis on technology and rationalism .

Type 5: Mobility by Use of Politics

- Several castes have used **politics in their attempt to better their condition or to achieve their goals**
- Use of politics, according to  **Eleanor Zelliot**, covers securing **governmental benefits and representation in legislative and political bodies**

Case: Mahars of Maharashtra

Mahars with the help of **military service** not only claimed a higher position in social hierarchy but also **exposed themselves to the Western culture**.

Case: Reddys & Kammas (Andhra Pradesh)

Eleanor Zelliot cited Reddys and Kammas of Andhra Pradesh as examples of castes achieving **political mobility**.

Case: Gujarat Lower Castes (Kothari & Maru)

 **Rajni Kothari and Rushikesh Maru** have given examples of some middle and lower castes and economically deprived communities in **Gujarat** who formed some organisations in **1940s and 1950s for achieving political power**. After winning elections against Congress, they were **accepted into the Kshatriya fold**.

C.3 Six Factors Responsible for Caste Mobility

#	FACTOR	SCHOLAR	DETAILS
1	Decline of the Jajmani System	—	The traditional jajmani system tied lower castes to hereditary occupations and ritual services for upper castes. With its decline due to monetisation of the economy, market integration, and urban migration , many service castes could break free from dependency on dominant castes → new occupations → upward mobility .
2	Emergence of Modern Occupations	Sharma (1974)	As industries, professions, and services expanded after colonial rule and modernisation, new occupational avenues opened up that were not linked to caste background . Entry into teaching, administration, technical professions allowed many lower and middle castes to improve their social status .
3	Decline of Untouchability & Purity-Pollution Principle	Pauline Kolenda (1986)	Caste hierarchies were maintained by strict notions of ritual purity and pollution . With social reform movements, urbanisation, and state laws , these restrictions began to weaken. The decline of untouchability practices allowed Dalits and other marginalised groups to access education, employment, and public spaces → upward mobility.
4	Education	—	Access to modern education created a pathway for marginalised castes to enter respected professions, government jobs, and leadership positions . Education also fostered social awareness , enabling oppressed groups to challenge caste-based inequalities .
5	State Policy of Protective Discrimination	—	Constitutional provisions like reservation in education, government jobs, and political representation gave Scheduled Castes,

			Scheduled Tribes, and Other Backward Classes opportunities to achieve mobility that was historically denied. These policies acted as a structural lever for change .
6	Social Movements	—	Movements led by leaders like Jyotiba Phule, Periyar, B.R. Ambedkar and others mobilised oppressed communities against caste oppression. Dalit movements, backward caste mobilisations, and regional caste associations pushed for rights, dignity, and recognition. Such movements provided both symbolic and material bases for social mobility.

C.4 Downward Caste Mobility (5 Types)

1. Abolition of Zamindari & Jagirdari (Rajasthan Case)

- Land reforms forced many **Rajputs, Brahmins, and Jats** (once Zamindars) into **economic decline**
- Some became **manual and agricultural labourers**, a sharp fall from their earlier status

Case: Sharma (1968) — Rajasthan Villages

Found **ex-Zamindars working alongside Dalits in famine relief works**, showing drastic downward mobility.

2. Impact of Green Revolution & Agrarian Capitalism

- Mechanisation and capitalist farming led to **pauperisation of small peasants and tenants**, while rich tenants rose as capitalist farmers
- Saith and Tankha (1972)** — sections of middle and lower peasants experienced **downward mobility despite technological progress**

3. Domain-specific Decline among Service Castes

- Barbers** — gave up polluting tasks (e.g., cleaning plates) → lost patronage from upper castes, splitting into sub-groups and facing **economic hardships**
- Balais (leather workers)** — discarded leather work to gain ritual status but ended up migrating as **casual labourers due to loss of livelihood**

4. Failed Upward Mobility of Scheduled Castes

Case: Regars (Leather Workers) — 1971-72

Regars (leather workers) in Rajasthan, Haryana, and Western UP attempted to **renounce leather work** (1971-72). They faced **harassment from dominant Jats** and severe livelihood insecurity, forcing many to **revert to their traditional occupation within months**.

5. Withdrawal of Status Respect (Jagirdars)

- Post-abolition, **Jagirdars in Rajasthan** lost not only land but also political clout
- Some **withdrew completely from Panchayat politics** due to the humiliation of competing with lower castes, marking a decline in **both social and political domains**

Conclusion: Caste mobility in India shows that **the caste system, though rigid, has never been completely static**. Communities have moved upward through warfare, service to rulers, Sanskritisation, census claims, and politics, while modern factors like education, social movements, and state policies further enabled mobility. At the same time, structural changes like **land reforms and the Green Revolution also pushed some castes downward**. Thus, caste mobility is a **two-way process shaped by history, economy, politics, and culture**, making it central to understanding Indian society.

ANTHROPOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

- **Challenge to static models:** Caste mobility disproves the colonial-era view of caste as a **frozen, unchanging system**. Anthropologists like Srinivas showed that **fluidity existed within hierarchy** — essential for UPSC answers on "change within continuity"
- **Sanskritization critique:** While Srinivas showed upward mobility through emulation, **Ambedkar argued** this merely reinforced the caste system by accepting its legitimacy — true mobility requires **annihilation of caste, not climbing within it**
- **Census & identity politics:** Risley's census rankings show how **colonial knowledge systems co-produced caste identities** — relevant to understanding current debates on OBC sub-categorisation, Jat/Patidar/Maratha demands
- **Downward mobility ignored:** Most scholarship focused on upward mobility; the downward cases (Regars, Balais, ex-Zamindars) reveal that **structural economic changes can undo ritual status gains** — important for understanding landless upper castes today
- **Contemporary:** Modern caste mobility is increasingly through **education & politics** rather than Sanskritization — e.g., Dalit entrepreneurship, OBC political parties, SC/ST representation in bureaucracy. This shifts the conversation from **ritual to material bases of mobility**
- **Gender dimension:** Caste mobility often came at the **cost of women's freedoms** — Sanskritizing castes imposed stricter purdah, dowry, and dietary restrictions on women to claim higher status

HANDWRITTEN ANNOTATIONS INDEX (All 14)

#	HANDWRITTEN NAME	CONTEXT / WHAT IT SAYS	SECTION
1	 Hutton	Criticised Brahmanical Theory — caste didn't originate when Brahmins had political power, caste is older	A.2 Brahmanical Theory
2	 D.N. Majumdar	Criticised Nesfield's Occupational Theory — status depends on purity of blood & isolation , not occupation hierarchy	A.4 Occupational Theory
3	 Dahlmann	Criticised Senart's Theory — origin of caste cannot be explained by certain elements only; needs multiple forces	A.6 Senart's Theory
4	 D.N. Majumdar (1952)	Criticised Hutton's Mana Theory — other societies have mana belief but no caste system	A.7 Hutton's Theory
5	 S.C. Roy & R.K. Mukherjee	Supported Multifactor Theory — several factors working together led to caste	A. Conclusion
6	 Yogendra Yadav	Shows how dominant OBC castes act as " vote banks " shaping regional parties (RJD, SP)	B.9 Contemporary Significance
7	 S.C. Dube & Peter Gardner	Dominance is often by individuals or factions within a caste, not the caste as a whole	B.10 Criticism #1
8	 D.N. Majumdar	Mohana village study (UP, 1958) — Thakur dominance weakened after zamindari abolition; retained some power through moneylending	B.10 Criticism #2
9	 Andre Beteille & Yogendra Singh	Under adult suffrage, numerical strength became crucial for political dominance , especially for SCs/STs with reserved seats	B.10 Criticism #4
10	 Silverberg	Social mobility through renunciation — lower castes performed acts of sannyasins to increase social value	C.1 Definition
11	 M.N. Srinivas	Explained caste mobility through Sanskritization & Westernization ; gave Shivaji as example of mobility through warfare	C.2 Types 1 & 4
12	 Pauline Kolenda	Caste mobility through warfare — acquisition of territory through conquest or peaceful occupancy	C.2 Type 1
13	 Eleanor Zelliot	Mobility by use of politics — securing governmental benefits & representation in legislative bodies	C.2 Type 5
14	 Rajni Kothari & Rushikesh Maru	Gujarat middle/lower castes formed political organisations in 1940s-50s ; after winning elections, accepted into Kshatriya fold	C.2 Type 5

QUICK-REVISION CHEAT SHEET

TOPIC	MAIN POINTS (KEYWORDS)	KEY SCHOLARS	EXAMPLES	KEY CASE STUDIES
Traditional Theory	Divine ordinance, Brahma's body, Karma of previous incarnation, Swabhav & Guna, Mythical vs Metaphysical versions	M.N. Srinivas (critic — jati ≠ varna, "gross oversimplification")	Born to rule → Kshatriya (Metaphysical)	—
Brahmanical Theory	Ingenious device by Brahmins, purity preservation, restrictions on eating/marriage, special privileges in texts, excluded aborigines & Sudras	Abbe Dubois (proponent), Ghurye (agrees), Hutton (critic)	Brahmana texts giving Brahmin superiority; excluding Sudras	—
Racial Theory	Clash of races, Aryan ceremonial purity, patrilineal vs matrilineal, chandalas (lowest), half-breeds, racial superiority, 6 processes of caste formation	Risley	Maria Gonds (MP) — Hinduisation; Rajbanshis (Bengal); religious enthusiasts forming sects	—
Occupational Theory	Functions/occupations, hereditary skills, occupational guilds → castes, hierarchy = occupation superiority	Nesfield , D.N. Majumdar (critic — purity of blood, not occupation)	—	—
Ketkar's Theory	Early endogamous tribes, hostile for resources, developed tribes = converted groups	Ketkar	—	Pre-Vedic tribes ≠ caste creators (post-Vedic origin)
Senart's Theory	Aryan sources, India-Rome-Greece parallel (family/gotra/caste = gens/curia/tribe = family/phratria/phyle), panchayat parallels, natural Aryan development	Senart (1930), Dahlmann (critic — needs multiple forces)	Panchayat/Sarpanch parallels in all 3 civilisations	—
Hutton's Mana	Mana = mysterious impersonal power, taboos on commensality/marriage/interaction, food infected with dangerous mana	Hutton (1961), D.N. Majumdar (1952 critic — mana exists elsewhere but no caste)	—	Nagas (1923-24) — refused presents/money from strangers for fear of mana
Multifactor	Multiple forces: religious, cultural, economic, political → long historical process → complex & multifaceted	S.C. Roy & R.K. Mukherjee	—	—
Dominant Caste	3 criteria: land, numbers, ritual rank. 3 NEW: political clout, western education, admin jobs. Village → regional shift. Sanskritization targets dominant caste not Brahmins. Culture watchdog, dispute settler. Absentee landlords replaced.	M.N. Srinivas (concept), Andre Beteille (2003, beyond land), Yogendra Yadav (vote banks), S.C. Dube & Peter Gardner (individuals vs caste), D.N. Majumdar (Mohana village), Yogendra Singh	Lingayat/Okkaliga (Mysore), Reddy/Kamma (AP), Gounder/Padayachi/Mudaliar (TN), Nair (Kerala), Maratha (MH), Patidar (GJ), Rajput/Jat/Giyar/Ahir (North India)	Rampura (Srinivas), Thakur landlords (Eastern UP), Jat landlords (Punjab), Mohana village UP 1958 (Majumdar), Yadavs in Bihar/UP (Lalu, Mulayam), BSP rise in UP, Dalit movements MH
Caste Mobility — Upward (5 types)	Warfare (conquest/empty land), serving rulers (higher varna), census (varna titles 1891-1931), Sanskritization (vegetarianism, teetotalism) & Westernization (technology, rationalism), politics (legislative representation)	Silverberg (renunciation), Pauline Kolenda (warfare), M.N. Srinivas (Sanskritization/Westernization), Herbert Risley (census), Eleanor Zelliot (politics), Rajni Kothari & Rushikesh Maru (Gujarat)	Shivaji (Sudra → Kshatriya, Marathas), Patidars of Gujarat (Shudra → Kshatriya), Kurmi Kshatriyas (Bengal), Teli → Vaishyas, Mahars (MH, military + politics)	Gujarat castes 1940s-50s political orgs → Kshatriya fold; Reddys & Kammas political mobility
6 Enabling Factors	Jajmani decline (monetisation, market), modern occupations (non-caste jobs), untouchability decline (reform, laws), education (awareness), reservation (structural lever), social movements (symbolic + material)	Sharma (1974), Pauline Kolenda (1986), Jyotiba Phule , Periyar , B.R. Ambedkar	—	—
Downward Mobility (5 types)	Zamindari/Jagirdari abolition, Green Revolution pauperisation, service caste domain-specific decline, failed SC upward mobility, Jagirdar withdrawal from politics	Sharma (1968, Rajasthan), Saith & Tankha (1972, Green Revolution)	Barbers (lost patronage), Balais (leather → casual labour), Regars (leather workers)	Rajasthan ex-Zamindars in famine relief with Dalits; Regars (1971-72) tried to renounce leather → harassment by Jats → reverted; Jagirdars withdrew from Panchayat politics

BUILDING BLOCKS — Most Important Scholars & Examples by PYQ Theme

TOPIC / PYQ THEME	MUST-USE SCHOLARS	MUST-USE EXAMPLES / CASE STUDIES	KEY CONCEPTS TO DROP IN ANSWERS	POSSIBLE QUESTIONS
Theories of Origin of Caste HIGH FREQ	Risley (Racial + 6 processes), Nesfield (Occupational), Hutton (Mana), Abbe Dubois & Ghurye (Brahmanical), Senart (Aryan), Ketkar (Tribal), M.N. Srinivas (jati ≠ varna), D.N. Majumdar (critic ×2), Dahlmann (critic), S.C. Roy & R.K. Mukherjee (Multifactor)	Maria Gonds & Rajbanshis (Hinduisation), Nagas 1923-24 (mana fear), India-Rome-Greece parallel (Senart), Occupational guilds → castes	Supernatural-centred society, gross oversimplification, jati as real unit, purity of blood vs occupation, endogamous tribes, mana as impersonal power, multifactor approach, long historical process	Critically examine theories of caste origin. Which theory best explains the caste system? Is caste unique to India?
Dominant Caste VERY HIGH FREQ	M.N. Srinivas (concept + Rampura), Andre Beteille (2003 — beyond land), Yogendra Yadav (vote banks), S.C. Dube & Peter Gardner (individuals vs caste), D.N. Majumdar (Mohana village 1958), Yogendra Singh	Rampura village, Thakur landlords (UP), Jat landlords (Punjab), Yadavs Bihar/UP, BSP in UP, Lingayats Karnataka, Reddys AP, Mohana village UP, Dalit movements MH	Absentee landlords, regional level dominance, culture watchdog, vote banks, sanskritization targets dominant caste (not always Brahmins), caste-based social stratification, power = land + numbers + ritual rank + NEW criteria	Define dominant caste. How are criteria changing? Is the concept still relevant? Critically evaluate with examples.
Caste Mobility HIGH FREQ	Silverberg (renunciation), M.N. Srinivas (Sanskritization/Westernization), Pauline Kolenda (warfare + purity-pollution 1986), Herbert Risley (census ranking), Eleanor Zelliot (politics), Rajni Kothari & Rushikesh Maru (Gujarat), Sharma (1974 occupations; 1968 downward), Saith & Tankha (1972)	Shivaji Sudra → Kshatriya, Patidars Gujarat, Kurmi Kshatriyas, Teli → Vaishyas, Mahars MH, Gujarat castes 1940s-50s, Regars 1971-72, Rajasthan ex-Zamindars, Barbers & Balais decline	Politicisation of castes, vegetarianism & teetotalism, technology & rationalism, two-way process (upward AND downward), structural lever, protective discrimination, pauperisation, renunciation	Discuss caste mobility in India. Is caste system truly rigid? Explain upward & downward mobility with examples. Role of politics in caste mobility.
Cross-Cutting: Caste & Politics MEDIUM	Yogendra Yadav, Rajni Kothari, Eleanor Zelliot, Srinivas (dominant caste), Ambedkar, Andre Beteille	Yadavs (RJD/SP), Mahars MH, Reddys/Kammas AP, BSP in UP, Gujarat organisations 1940s-50s, Panchayati Raj impact	Vote banks, caste associations, political mobilisation, adult franchise, Panchayati Raj, reserved seats, democratic decentralisation	How has democracy affected caste? Discuss politicisation of caste and casteisation of politics.
Cross-Cutting: Caste & Social Change MEDIUM	Srinivas (Sanskritization, Westernization, Dominant Caste), Kolenda (purity-pollution), Phule, Periyar, Ambedkar, Sharma, Andre Beteille	Thakurs emulated in UP, Jats emulated in Punjab, Dalit movements MH, land reform impacts, Green Revolution, Regars & Balais failures	Emulation, cultural hegemony, erosion & contestation, social movements as mobility enablers, reservation as structural change, two-way mobility, change within continuity	Is caste system changing? Discuss factors of social change in caste. Compare Sanskritization vs Westernization as mobility routes.

Source: Sarathi IAS Foundation — Handout 3 (Nataraj Sir) • Paper 2, Chapter 3.2

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